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"All the News That's Fit to Print"

The New York Times

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THE WEATHER
Today, sunny, chilly, some wind, high 47. **Tonight,** partly cloudy, low 38. **Tomorrow,** morning sunshine, increasing afternoon clouds, high 52. Weather map appears on Page B8.

DAKOTA SANTIAGO FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

The jet's nose was cantilevered upward after its cockpit was partly sheared off. Most of the 41 people hospitalized had been released.

Trump's Claim on Talks Elicits Gains in Market, And Denials From Iran

West's Oil Producers Reap Profits Now but Stay Wary

By REBECCA F. ELLIOTT

HOUSTON — Western companies that pump and process oil and natural gas are among the biggest beneficiaries of the war with Iran, which has snarled production and shipping of fuels in the Persian Gulf.

But even as many of them reap the rewards of much more expensive energy, executives are worried that what comes next could be bad for business.

Should the war end — a possibility made more real when President Trump said on Monday that the United States and Iran had "very strong" talks about ending hostilities — prices could tumble. If oil and gas prices quickly returned to levels that prevailed at the end of last year, many companies would have to go back to worrying about trimming budgets and laying off workers.

If, on the other hand, attacks on energy infrastructure intensify and it remains too dangerous for most ships to carry oil and gas out of the Persian Gulf, prices most likely will keep climbing. That, over time, will lead governments, businesses and consumers to find ways to use less oil and gas — and some of those changes could permanently reduce demand for the fuels.

"It feels like you should be jumping up and down," said Ron Gusek, chief executive of Liberty Energy, an oil field service company that works for many of the biggest American producers. But, he added in an interview, "there is a picture out there where the economic realities of our world get very, very challenged again."

That uncertainty was on full display in Houston on Monday, where thousands of energy executives and government officials gathered for the industry's most important annual conference, CERAWeek by S&P Global.

"The markets are trading on scant information," Mike Wirth, chief executive of the U.S. oil giant Chevron, said at the conference, adding that he thinks physical supply chains are tighter than commodity futures prices reflect.

Oil prices climbed as much as 65 percent in the weeks after the United States and Israel began attacking Iran on Feb. 28 but have since retreated somewhat. Natural gas is more expensive, too, particularly in Europe and Asia, which depend heavily on imports.

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Messages Exchanged Said to Fall Short of Negotiations

*This article is by **Luke Broadwater, Aaron Boxerman, Erika Solomon** and **Thomas Fuller**.*

WASHINGTON — President Trump said on Monday that the United States and Iran were negotiating a "total resolution of our hostilities in the Middle East," backing away from his threats over the weekend to attack Iranian power plants.

Mr. Trump said Jared Kushner, his son-in-law, and Steve Witkoff, one of his most senior advisers, were leading the talks.

"We have had very, very strong talks," Mr. Trump told reporters on Monday. "We'll see where they lead. We have major points of agreement."

The prospect of negotiations to end the war launched by the United States and Israel on Feb. 28 sharply reversed some of the steep declines in global financial markets. But Iran publicly denied that negotiations were taking place, with the speaker of Iran's Parliament taking to social media to call it fake news.

Still, according to four Iranian officials and an Iranian diplomat, Tehran and Washington have been exchanging messages through intermediaries about de-escalating the conflict, though the messages appeared to be short of negotiations. The talks aimed to avert attacks on critical energy infrastructure. Three officials said Iran's foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, and Mr. Witkoff had spoken on the phone in recent days in what were described as preliminary discussions.

Mr. Trump's dizzying fluctuations in recent days have raised many questions about whether an end to the war might truly be at hand and if the blockage of oil shipments that have rocked the global economy will be resolved.

With the war now in its fourth week, Iran's main leverage in the conflict remains oil. Its price has risen more than 50 percent since late February, amid a de facto Iranian stranglehold on the critical Strait of Hormuz in the Persian Gulf. The International Energy Agency, which was created by industrialized economies in the 1970s to confront disruptions to

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LIMBO Gazans feel forgotten as the Iran war slows recovery and panic buying returns. PAGE A7

JUSTICES IMPERIL MAIL-IN VOTE LAW

Doubts Over Mississippi May Signal U.S. Shift

By ABBIE VANSICKLE

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court's conservative majority on Monday appeared poised to reject Mississippi's mail-in ballot law, a decision that could upend mail-in voting throughout the country.

At issue is whether Mississippi's law, which allows ballots postmarked by Election Day to be counted if they are received within five business days after the election, is legal given that federal law requires votes to be cast by that day.

The outcome of the case could have sweeping consequences for voters in the midterm elections, potentially creating chaos among states that allow mail-in balloting. Mississippi and at least 18 other states and territories — including 2026 battleground districts in Nevada and California — allow late ballots to be counted.

President Trump has long opposed mail-in voting and has falsely claimed that the practice was a source of fraud and contributed to his defeat in the 2020 presidential election.

He has encouraged Republicans to support legislation outlawing mail-in voting, and his administration backed the challenge to the Mississippi law in hopes of halting vote counts that continue after Election Day.

The Republican-led Mississippi legislature adopted the law allowing late arriving ballots to be counted in 2020, during the pandemic. It is being challenged by the Republican National Committee and Mississippi's state G.O.P.

During more than two hours of argument on Monday, the court's six conservative justices repeatedly pressed the lawyer for Mississippi on what is required to make a ballot selection fully complete, suggesting that federal law sets out Election Day as the day ballots should be considered final.

"So when do I know whether or not a choice is final?" Justice Clarence Thomas asked.

Several other conservative justices including Justice Amy Coney Barrett, who is often a key vote, also had sharp questions for Mississippi. They focused on how the state could guarantee a ballot had officially been cast by Election

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Distraction May Have Role in LaGuardia Crash

2 Pilots Killed as Plane Strikes a Fire Truck

By CHRISTOPHER MAAG

"Stop, Truck 1, stop!"

The desperate call from an air traffic controller late Sunday night came seconds before the first fatal collision at LaGuardia Airport in exactly 34 years.

The call came too late.

Two pilots were killed and dozens were injured when an Air Canada Express jet collided on a runway with a fire truck as it landed at LaGuardia Airport at about 11:45 p.m. Sunday. The force of the crash ejected a flight attendant, who was tossed from the plane and landed on the runway still strapped to her seat.

The collision shut down one of the busiest airports in the region, exacerbating flight cancellations and delays across the country amid a partial federal government shutdown.

The fire truck had been deployed to respond to an aborted takeoff by a United Airlines flight, Bryan Bedford, administrator of the Federal Aviation Administration, said at a news conference at LaGuardia on Monday afternoon.

Leaders of the National Transportation Safety Board were gathering at LaGuardia on Monday to begin the agency's investigation. The cause of the crash had not been determined on Monday, but a recording of communications between air traffic controllers and personnel on the ground suggests that controllers might have been distracted around the time of the collision by the United flight emergency.

Moments before the crash, workers on a fire truck requested permission to cross a primary runway at LaGuardia to respond to an aircraft whose crew had reported an issue with odor in the cabin, said Kathryn Garcia, executive director of the Port Authority of New York and New Jersey, which operates the airport. Flight attendants had reported feeling ill because of the odor, she said.

As Air Canada Express Flight 8646 descended through a light drizzle toward LaGuardia's runway No. 4-22, the flight tower ap-

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Overview of the Crash

A fire truck crossed the runway just as an Air Canada passenger plane was landing on Sunday night at LaGuardia Airport.

Sources: Flightradar24; aerial image from Google Earth. AGNES CHANG, LAZARO GAMIO AND LALENA FISHER/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Groups Strain to Care for Pets Left in ICE's Wake

By MIRIAM JORDAN

NEW ORLEANS — The adoption listing described Heinz, a Shih Tzu-poodle mix, as sweet, happy and energetic.

"But he also has a sad story," said the bio on the website of Rolling River Rescue, a nonprofit in New Orleans.

The caramel-colored pup hadn't run away, nor had he been given up by owners who no longer wanted him. He had "lost his family," the listing said, as a result of "recent events in New Orleans," a reference to immigration enforcement that has swept up people under President Trump's mass deportation campaign.

Federal agents have conducted large-scale crackdowns in New Orleans, Chicago, Los Angeles and Minneapolis, and smaller roundups from Hawaii to Maine. Hundreds of thousands of immigrants have been arrested. Most have remained locked up and many have been deported.

Left behind have been their dogs, cats and bunnies, even chickens, according to pet rescue groups and animal control agencies.

"What many Americans don't realize is that there are companion animals being left by families that disappeared overnight," said

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KATHLEEN FLYNN FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Counting stray dogs in the neighborhood of East New Orleans.

Trump's Crackdown on Fraud Excludes Dozens He Pardons

Many Beneficiaries Are Donors and Allies

By MATTHEW PURDY and LUKE BROADWATER

Salomon Melgen was an immigrant who came to the United States and wound up committing fraud, ripping off the American taxpayers by $42 million. "Melgen devised a scheme to enrich himself by defrauding Medicare to the tune of tens of millions of dollars," an F.B.I. official said when Mr. Melgen was sentenced to 17 years in jail during President Trump's first term.

Given the high-profile "war on fraud" in government programs that Mr. Trump announced last week, pointing to scams allegedly carried out by Somali and other immigrants, Mr. Melgen might have a prominent place in the president's rogues' gallery of fraudsters.

But Mr. Melgen is actually prominent in another presidential lineup, the gallery of criminals convicted of fraud who have been granted clemency by Mr. Trump.

That second gallery is not small.

Across both of his terms, Mr. Trump has granted clemency to more than 70 allies, donors and others convicted in fraud cases. In his second term, Mr. Trump's pace of pardoning those convicted of fraud has increased. In the first year of his second term, he handed out nearly three dozen pardons and commutations for people accused of fraud.

Mr. Trump is unabashed about

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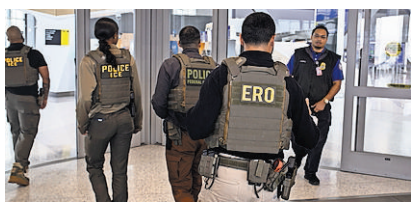
Trump Tells G.O.P. to Dig In
The president said Republicans should stop negotiating with Democrats to end the partial shutdown. PAGE A13

ICE Agents Arrive at Airports
The deployment to assist understaffed security teams did not appear to ease the pain of many travelers. PAGE A13



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Hailing the Start of Spring
The Newroz holiday comes at a critical time, as Kurds in Turkey push for peace while their brethren in Syria and Iran fear further conflict. PAGE A4

A Darkened Sky in Cuba
From rural provinces to the trash-filled capital, the nation is reeling from an energy crisis as U.S. officials pressure its former fuel suppliers. PAGE A10

Drones Just a Few Clicks Away
Ukraine has created online marketplaces to let units select their own, a break from generations of centralized arms procurement. PAGE A8

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Chatbots Want Health Records
Following Amazon and OpenAI, Microsoft is upgrading its artificially intelligent assistant to track your health. That comes with benefits and risks. PAGE B1

Delinquency and Default
A record 7.7 million borrowers defaulted on $181 billion in federal student loans last year, new data showed. PAGE B1

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An American and a British critic found plenty to enjoy in the U.K.'s new version of "Saturday Night Live." PAGE C1

U.S. Director Wows London
After "Fiddler on the Roof" and a take on Sondheim, Jordan Fein is tackling Arthur Miller's "Broken Glass." PAGE C1

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Australia's experiment with the use of psychedelic medicine has led to positive outcomes, psychiatrists say. PAGE D1

Wicked Stepmother No More
A new look at ancient statuary suggests that a female pharaoh wasn't the villain that scholars took her to be. PAGE D1

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